

doc-mark-discipline-exercised

Affirms · Ecclesiology › Nature of the Church · doctrine · unanimous_lineages · confidence: high

Statement under examination

Faithful exercise of church discipline is a mark of a true visible church.

Rationale

Matt 18:15-18 institutes a graduated procedure culminating in ekklesia-level action with binding-and-loosing authority; 1 Cor 5:1-13 commands the assembled church to 'put away' (exarate, G1808, aorist imperative) the unrepentant offender and forbids table-fellowship; 2 Thess 3:6-15, 1 Tim 5:19-21, Titus 3:10-11, and Rev 2:14-16, 20 extend the pattern to idleness, persistent sin, divisiveness, and tolerated false teaching; 2 Cor 2:5-11 and Gal 6:1 fix the telos as restoration. The pan-canonical lexical pattern presents disciplined separation-with-a-view-to-restoration as a normative ecclesial duty, not an optional practice.

Reasoning

Yes. A church that ignores serious unrepented sin among its members and refuses to do anything about it is not functioning as Christ's church. The strongest reason from Scripture is Matthew 18:15-17, where Jesus himself gives a step-by-step procedure: first speak privately to the brother who sins, then bring one or two witnesses, then tell the whole assembled church, and if he still refuses to listen, treat him as outside the covenant community. 1 Corinthians 5 reinforces this with great force. Paul rebukes the Corinthians for tolerating a man living in open sexual sin and commands them to assemble and 'put away the evil person from among you,' even refusing table fellowship. Paul lists categories that warrant this action: sexual immorality, greed, idolatry, reviling, drunkenness, swindling. 2 Thessalonians 3:6 says to keep away from any brother walking in idleness. Titus 3:10 says reject a divisive person after two warnings. Revelation 2 rebukes whole churches for tolerating false teachers. The strongest counterargument also comes from Scripture. Critics point to Matthew 7:1 where Jesus says 'judge not, that you be not judged,' and to Romans 14 on not despising the weaker brother, and to Galatians 6:1 on restoring gently. Are these passages telling believers to leave each other alone? The answer holds because the same Jesus who said 'judge not' said 'tell it to the church' a few chapters later in Matthew 18, so Matthew 7 cannot mean 'never assess a brother's conduct.' It means do not condemn hypocritically or finally. 2 Corinthians 2:5-11 shows the goal is always restoration, not destruction. Galatians 6:1 calls for gentleness, not the absence of correction. The biblical pattern is graduated, witness-based, aimed at repentance, and willing to separate only when repentance is refused. Where the practice is honest and Christ-shaped, the church stays the church. Where it is abandoned, the leaven spreads through the whole lump.

Denominational landscape

Every major Christian lineage affirms that exercising discipline on serious unrepented sin is a duty of the church, but they package the teaching differently. The patristic tradition from the Didache forward built an early penitential system with public confession and reconciliation. The Catholic Church holds the Sacrament of Reconciliation as the ordinary means by which sinners are reconciled with God and with the visible Church, and maintains canonical penalties up to excommunication for grave offenses. Eastern Orthodoxy treats penance as the renewal of baptism and uses excommunication and the withholding of communion as ecclesial corrections. Lutheran confessions affirm the power of the keys to retain and remit sins and treat discipline through Word, absolution, and excommunication, but typically frame it as derivative of Word-and-Sacrament rather than as a separate constitutive mark of the church. Anglican

Article XXXIII directs that an excommunicated person be treated as a heathen and publican until reconciled. Reformed confessions (Belgic Article 29, Scots Confession, Westminster Confession 25 and 30) formally list ecclesiastical discipline as the third of three marks alongside the pure preaching of the Word and the right administration of the Sacraments. Anabaptist tradition through the Schleithem Confession Article II makes the ban a defining ecclesial practice. Methodist Article XXII rebukes those who openly break church rites and ceremonies. Pentecostal and continuationist movements such as the Assemblies of God affirm sanctification and church accountability structures, though the formal language of marks is rarely used. The places where the canonical proposition fails in practice are not denominational but functional, in segments of contemporary megachurch, seeker-sensitive, and hyper-grace movements that have effectively stopped exercising Matthew 18 and 1 Corinthians 5 even while affirming them on paper. No public-record cult or heterodox carrier of denial sits cleanly on this question, because formal denial of the duty of discipline is not a defining mark of the documented heretical movements (Mormonism, Jehovah's Witnesses, Iglesia ni Cristo, Branhamism, Christian Science). Several of those movements practice harsh disciplinary shunning of dissenters, which is a perversion of biblical discipline in the opposite direction.

Position thresholds

Would die for if challenged	No
Cult marker if denied	No
Would visit if otherwise	Yes
Would participate if otherwise	Yes
Would serve if otherwise	No
Would be member if otherwise	No
Would let children be taught otherwise	Yes
Would marry if held otherwise	Yes
Would publicly correct if otherwise	Yes

Notes

The proposition operates at two distinct levels and the answer must distinguish them. (a) Church discipline as a BIBLICAL PRACTICE commanded by Christ and the apostles is universally affirmed across historic Christianity in some form (Catholic Sacrament of Reconciliation, Eastern Orthodox penitential tradition, Lutheran absolution and excommunication via the keys, Anglican Article XXXIII, Reformed and Anabaptist confessional marks, Methodist Article XXII on rebuking those who break church rites, Pentecostal sanctification structures). On this the verdict is firm: yes, faithful exercise of discipline characterizes a true church. (b) The specific dogmatic formulation 'discipline is the third MARK of the true visible church' is Reformed-Anabaptist sixteenth-century confessional vocabulary (Belgic Confession Article 29, Scots Confession 1560, Schleithem 1527 on the ban). Lutheran confessions treat discipline as derivative of Word-and-Sacrament rather than a separate constitutive mark; Catholic and Eastern Orthodox ecclesiologies ground the church in apostolic succession, sacraments, and communion rather than enumerated 'marks' in the Reformation sense. So a church that practices faithful discipline but does not list it formally as a third mark satisfies the canonical proposition. A church that has DE FACTO ABANDONED discipline (large stretches of contemporary megachurch and seeker-sensitive movements that quietly stopped exercising Matt 18 and 1 Cor 5 even where principle is affirmed) falls under the canonical critique. Misreadings of Matt 7:1 ('judge not') as forbidding all assessment of professing-believer conduct contradict the same Jesus' command in Matt 18:15-17 and are pastorally serious but not gospel-denying.

cult_marker=false because discipline is not a Trinitarian or Christological boundary; would_die_for=false for the same reason. would_serve_if_otherwise=false and would_be_member_if_otherwise=false because a community that refuses to exercise discipline cannot keep itself from leavening (1 Cor 5:6-7) and serving in such a body underwrites the dysfunction.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: **yes**

Neutralized form. The faithful exercise of church discipline characterizes a true visible church.

Notes. The phrase 'a mark of a true visible church' is Reformed-confessional vocabulary (Belgic 29, Scots 18, WCF 25.4) functioning as a technical term of art for one of the three notae ecclesiae. Calling it 'a mark' loads the verdict toward a specific sixteenth-century Reformed-Anabaptist ecclesiology that Lutheran, Catholic, and Eastern Orthodox traditions do not share even where they affirm the underlying practice. The neutralized form preserves the canonical claim (discipline characterizes a true church) without forcing the Reformation marks-doctrine framework.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. covenant_theology, dispensationalism, new_covenant_theology

analogia scripturae invoked

Competing lens verdicts

covenant_theology · **affirms**: OT covenant-community purity ('put away the evil from your midst,' Deut 13/17/19) is continuous with NT ekklesia discipline (1 Cor 5:13 directly quotes Deut 17:7 LXX); covenantal continuity strengthens the pan-canonical case

dispensationalism · **affirms**: even on a strict church/Israel distinction the NT ecclesial commands of Matt 18, 1 Cor 5, 2 Thess 3, Titus 3, Rev 2 stand within the church-age and bind the church directly; no dispensational lens disables church-age discipline

new_covenant_theology · **affirms**: the NT commands carry their own warrant under the new covenant Christ inaugurated; the Mosaic formula is fulfilled and reapplied through 1 Cor 5:13

Verdict does not depend on a single framework. The lexical pattern is dense across Gospels, Pauline corpus, Pastorals, and Revelation. The Reformation 'three marks' formulation is one VALID confessional packaging of the canonical data, not a necessary one; Lutheran, Catholic, and Eastern Orthodox ecclesiologies affirm the underlying duty without the formal 'third mark' designation.

Scripture (apparatus + interlinear)

Matt.18.15-17 · **for** · genre: gospel

Key term. ἐκκλησία (ekklesiā) G1577; παρακούω (parakouō) G3878; ἔστω σοι ὡςπερ ὁ ἐθνικός (estō soi hōsper ho ethnikos) G1510/G1482

Force. Jesus gives a three-step procedure: private confrontation, two-or-three witnesses (echoing Deut 19:15), and finally telling the ekklesia (G1577, the assembled church, only here and Matt 16:18 in the Gospels); the imperative estō ('let him be') ranks the unrepentant brother with Gentiles and tax collectors, i.e., outside the covenant community for the purpose of fellowship; the verb parakouō is 'to refuse to hear' and triggers the next escalation step

Matt.18.18-20 · for · genre: gospel

Key term. δέω (deō) G1210; λύω (luō) G3089; δύο ἢ τρεῖς συνηγμένοι (dyo ē treis synēgmenoi) G1417/G5140/G4863

Force. the binding-and-loosing formula transfers ecclesial decision to heavenly ratification (perfect periphrastic in the Greek, 'shall have been bound/loosed in heaven' on a defensible reading); the assembled two-or-three constitute the discipline-exercising body in Jesus' name; this is the locus classicus of churchly discipline-with-divine-warrant

1Cor.5.1-13 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key term. παραδοῦναι τὸν τοιοῦτον τῷ Σατανᾷ (paradounai ton toiouton tō Satana) G3860/G4567; ἐξάρατε τὸν πονηρὸν ἐξ ὑμῶν αὐτῶν (exarate ton ponēron ex hymōn autōn) G1808/G4190; ζύμη (zymē) G2219; ὀλεθρος (olethros) G3639; σὰρξ (sarx) G4561

Force. Paul commands the assembled church to 'hand over' the unrepentant offender to Satan (paradounai, aorist active infinitive of paradidōmi G3860) for 'destruction of the flesh' so the spirit may be saved; the closing imperative exarate (aorist active imperative of exairō G1808) quotes Deut 17:7 LXX, anchoring NT discipline in the Mosaic 'put away the evil from your midst' formula; the leaven figure (zymē G2219) warrants the practice on contamination grounds (5:6, 'a little leaven leavens the whole lump'); v.11 forbids table-fellowship with the so-called brother who is sexually immoral, covetous, idolater, reviler, drunkard, or swindler

2Cor.2.5-11 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. ἐπιτιμία (epitimia) G2009; κυρῶσαι εἰς αὐτὸν ἀγάπην (kyrōsai eis auton agapēn) G2964/G26

Force. the disciplined offender of 1 Cor 5 (on the traditional reading) is now to be forgiven and restored; epitimia (G2009, 'penalty, censure') is sufficient when imposed by the majority; the imperative kyrōsai ('confirm, ratify') love toward him fixes the telos of discipline as restoration, not exclusion as an end in itself; Satan's stratagem is exposed where discipline becomes destruction rather than reclamation

2Cor.7.8-10 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. λύπη κατὰ θεόν (lypē kata theon) G3077/G2596/G2316; μετάνοια εἰς σωτηρίαν (metanoia eis sōtērian) G3341/G4991

Force. godly grief produces repentance unto salvation, the mechanism by which faithful discipline reaches its proper end; defines the diagnostic between worldly sorrow that produces death and the godly sorrow that discipline aims to provoke

2Thess.3.6-15 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. στέλλεσθαι (stellesthai) G4724; ἀτάκτως (ataktōs) G814; μὴ συναναμίγνυσθαι (mē synanamignysthai) G4874

Force. Paul commands the church 'in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ' to withdraw from any brother walking in idleness; the imperative stellesthai ('keep aloof, hold off') with synanamignysthai ('mix together with') in v.14 marks disciplined separation; v.15 specifies the spirit, 'do not regard him as an enemy but warn him as a brother,' preserving restorative intent

1Tim.5.19-21 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. ἐλέγχω (elegchō) G1651; οἱ ἁμαρτάνοντες (hoi hamartanontes) G264

Force. the present participle hoi hamartanontes ('those who continue in sin') is the target of public elegchō ('to expose, convict, rebuke') 'in the presence of all so that the rest may stand in fear'; even elders fall under this procedure with the two-or-three-witnesses safeguard from Deut 19:15; discipline reaches the highest offices

Titus.3.10-11 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key term. αἵρετικὸν ἄνθρωπον (hairetikon anthrōpon) G141; παραιτοῦ (paraitou) G3868

Force. the divisive/factional person (hairetikos G141, sectarian) is to be rejected (paraitou, present middle imperative of paraitomai G3868, 'shun, decline, have done with') after a first and second admonition; gives the procedural shape for handling persistent dividers of the church

Rev.2.14-16 · **for** · genre: apocalyptic

Key term. ἔχω κατὰ σοῦ ὀλίγα (echō kata sou oligā) G2192; μετανόησον (metanoēson) G3340

Force. the risen Christ rebukes Pergamum for tolerating the teaching of Balaam and the Nicolaitans within its midst; the imperative metanoēson ('repent') is addressed to the whole church for its failure to exercise discipline against false teachers; Thyatira (2:20) is rebuked likewise for tolerating Jezebel; the failure of churchly discipline is treated as an offense Christ himself will redress with the sword

Gal.6.1 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key term. καταρτίζω (katartizō) G2675; πνεῦμα πραΰτητος (pneuma prautētos) G4151/G4240

Force. the verb katartizō ('to mend, restore, set right,' used of mending nets in Matt 4:21) names the goal of confronting a brother caught in transgression; the manner is 'in a spirit of gentleness' (prautēs G4240), with watchful self-awareness; this verse balances 1 Cor 5's severity by fixing the spirit and aim of corrective action

Matt.7.1-5 · **complicates** · genre: gospel · figures: hyperbole

Key term. μὴ κρίνετε (mē krinete) G2919

Force. the prohibition against judgmental hypocrisy is the standard counter-text raised against church discipline; the imperative mē krinete is a present prohibition against ongoing judgmental disposition, not a ban on assessment as such; v.5 ends with 'then you will see clearly to take the speck out of your brother's eye,' which presupposes corrective action after self-examination; the same Jesus commands 'tell it to the church' in Matt 18:17; Matt 7:1 limits the spirit, not the duty

Rom.14.1-13 · **complicates** · genre: epistle

Key term. μὴ ἐξουθενεῖτε (mē exoutheneite) G1848; μηκέτι κρίνωμεν ἀλλήλους (mēketi krinōmen allēlous) G2919

Force. Paul forbids despising or judging brothers over disputable matters (food, days); the scope is adiaphora, not the catalogue of grave sins in 1 Cor 5:11; the passage restricts where discipline does NOT apply and so functions as a guardrail against discipline misapplied to indifferent matters; it does not retract the discipline of unrepented sexual immorality, idolatry, or divisive false teaching

Deut.17.7 · **for** · genre: law

Key term. וְהָיָה עִרְבָאָהּ מִכִּירְבֶּכְהָ (uvi'arta hara mikkirbekha) H1197/H7451

Force. the Mosaic 'put away the evil from your midst' formula recurs across Deuteronomy (13:5, 17:7, 19:19, 21:21, 22:21-24, 24:7) and is quoted in LXX by Paul at 1 Cor 5:13; the Hebrew verb ba'ar (H1197, 'to burn, consume, purge') frames covenantal community-purity as a duty of the assembled people; canonical continuity between OT covenant assembly and NT ekklesia is on the lexical surface

Concordance lemmas traversed

G1577, G3878, G1510, G1482, G1210, G3089, G3860, G4567, G1808, G4190, G2219, G3639, G4561, G2009, G2964, G3077, G3341, G4724, G814, G4874, G1651, G264, G141, G3868, G2675, G4240, G2919, G1848, G2192, G3340, H1197, H7451

complicating texts searched: Yes

Counter-witness traditions

patristic · Didache 15.3 (Lake, Apostolic Fathers); Tertullian, De Paenitentia; Hippolytus, Apostolic Tradition; early-third-century penitential system · affirms · unverified

“early church developed graduated penitential discipline including public confession, exclusion from communion, and reconciliation upon repentance; admonish one another not in anger but in peace as you have it in the Gospel”

catholic_magisterial · Catechism of the Catholic Church 1422-1498 on the Sacrament of Penance and Reconciliation; canonical penalties including excommunication · affirms · unverified

“those who approach the Sacrament of Penance obtain pardon from God's mercy for the offense committed against him and are at the same time reconciled with the Church which they have wounded by their sins”

lutheran · Augsburg Confession XI (Confession), XII (Repentance), XXVIII (Ecclesiastical Power) · affirms · verified

“the power of the Keys is a power or commandment of God to preach the Gospel, to remit and retain sins, and to administer Sacraments; the Church ought to impart absolution to those returning to repentance”

anglican · Thirty-Nine Articles, Article XXXIII (Of excommunicate Persons, how they are to be avoided) · affirms · unverified

“that person which by open denunciation of the Church is rightly cut off from the unity of the Church and excommunicated, ought to be taken of the whole multitude of the faithful as an Heathen and Publican until he be openly reconciled”

reformed · Belgic Confession Article 29; Scots Confession 1560 ch. 18; Westminster Confession 25.4 and 30 · affirms · unverified

“the marks by which the true Church is known are these: if the pure doctrine of the gospel is preached, if it makes use of the pure administration of the sacraments, and if church discipline is exercised in punishing of sin”

methodist · Methodist Articles of Religion XXII (Of the Rites and Ceremonies of Churches) · affirms · verified

“whosoever, through his private judgment, willingly and purposely doth openly break the rites and ceremonies of the church to which he belongs, ought to be rebuked openly, that others may fear to do the like”

anabaptist · Schleithem Confession 1527, Article II (the Ban) · affirms · verified

“the same shall be admonished twice in secret and the third time openly disciplined or banned according to the command of Christ (Matthew 18)”

eastern_orthodox · Orthodox Church in America, teaching on Penance / Confession; Eastern penitential canons · affirms · verified

“penance is the renewal of baptism when sin breaks communion with God; confession is the open acknowledgment of sin before God, with absolution and reconciliation through the Church”

pentecostal · Assemblies of God Statement of Fundamental Truths; classical Pentecostal sanctification and accountability structures · affirms · unverified

“Pentecostal bodies affirm sanctification and the church's responsibility to address unrepented sin among members; congregational discipline practiced though not framed in Reformation marks language”

Web sources

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/matthew/18-17.htm>

“ekklesia G1577; parakouo G3878 'refuse to hear'; esto G1510 imperative 'let him be to you as a Gentile and tax collector’”

supports · category: interlinear · https://biblehub.com/interlinear/1_corinthians/5-13.htm

“Exarate G1808 aorist imperative 'put away'; poneron G4190 'the evil one'; quotes Deut 17:7 LXX in the canonical pattern”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/titus/3-10.htm>

“hairetikos G141 'factions, sectarian'; paraiteomai G3868 'shun, decline, have done with' after first and second admonition”

supports · category: interlinear · https://biblehub.com/interlinear/2_thessalonians/3-6.htm

“stellesthai G4724 'keep aloof'; ataktos G814 'disorderly, idle'; in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ”

supports · category: interlinear · https://biblehub.com/interlinear/1_timothy/5-20.htm

“elegcho G1651 'rebuke, expose, convict'; present participle hamartanontas G264 'those continuing in sin'; publicly so others may fear”

nuance · category: interlinear · https://biblehub.com/interlinear/2_corinthians/2-6.htm

“epitimia G2009 'penalty, censure' is sufficient; the telos of discipline is restoration not destruction”

nuance · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/galatians/6-1.htm>

“katartizo G2675 'restore, mend' in a spirit of prautes G4240 'gentleness'; fixes the manner of corrective action”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://bookofconcord.org/augsburg-confession/>

“the power of the Keys is a power or commandment of God to preach the Gospel, to remit and retain sins, and to administer Sacraments (Augsburg XXVIII)”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://courses.washington.edu/hist112/SCHLEITHEIM%20CONFESSION%20OF%20FAITH.htm>

“the same shall be admonished twice in secret and the third time openly disciplined or banned according to the command of Christ (Schleitheim Article II)”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://www.umc.org/en/content/articles-of-religion>

“whosoever willingly and purposely doth openly break the rites and ceremonies of the church to which he belongs, ought to be rebuked openly (Methodist Article XXII)”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://www.oca.org/orthodoxy/the-orthodox-faith/worship/the-sacraments/penance>

“penance is the renewal of baptism when sin breaks communion with God; confession is the open acknowledgment of sin with absolution through the Church”

Flags

- stem-pre-loaded-verdict